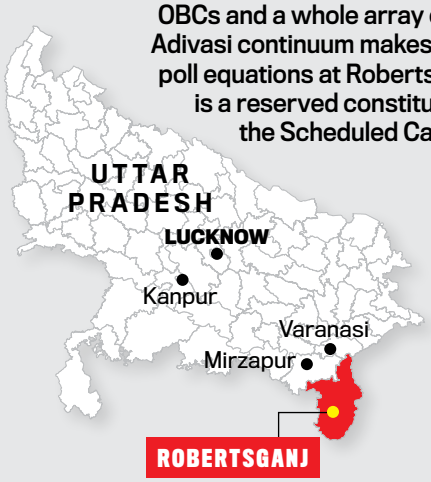


WELFARE AT HEART
Surender Kol in Jamsoti village, deep in the forested hills, is happy with his free rations and is a votary of continuity. The Kols, classified as SC in Robertsganj, are a relatively small demographic pool, about 75,000-80,000, but have seen four triumphs in the past five elections since 2004

Caste Cause

A unique mix of forward caste groups, OBCs and a whole array on the Dalit-Adivasi continuum makes for complex poll equations at Robertsganj, which is a reserved constituency for the Scheduled Castes



DALIT BREAK-UP

Chamar
225,000

Kharwar
100,000

Kol
75,000-80,000

Chamars are the biggest Dalit caste here but had their last MP in 1989. Smaller groups like the Kols suit the forward castes better

Total voters: 1.77 million

One of the 80 Lok Sabha constituencies of Uttar Pradesh, Robertsganj comprises part of Chandauli district and all of Sonbhadra district. The constituency is **reserved for the Scheduled Castes**, like 16 others in UP, and 84 across India

2019	2014
Winner: **Pakaudi Lal Kol**	Winner: **Chhotelal Kharwar**
Apna Dal (Sonelal)	*BJP*
Vote share: 45.3%	***Vote share: 42.7%***
Vs	Vs
Runner-up	Runner-up
Bhai Lal Kol	**Sharada Prasad**
Samajwadi Party	*Bahujan Samaj Party*
Vote share: 39.8%	***Vote share: 21.1%***

Chakia is an unclassifiable little blur of semi-urbanity caught in a stage of evolution somewhere between town and kasba. Instead of the road shooting straight southeast from Banaras to Robertsganj, the 'capital' of Sonbhadra district, a long, horseshoe detour brings you further out into these semi-hilly hinterlands. It's still Chandauli district, but a part of it that falls in the Robertsganj Lok Sabha constituency, which also covers all of Sonbhadra. The very south-eastern tip of Uttar Pradesh, Sonbhadra is the only district in the state that borders four others: clockwise, Bihar, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Here, a lot of things collide: ethnicities, languages, landscapes, histories.

The heterogeneity makes for complex electoral equations because Robertsganj—voting on June 1—is one of the 17 seats in UP that are reserved for the Scheduled Castes. There are 84 Lok Sabha constituencies across India that are kept for the SCs under Article 330 of the Constitution. All parties have to field Dalits here—scholars call it "compensatory discrimination", and it is intended to guarantee a minimum representation to these marginalised groups (as is done for Adivasis in the 47 seats reserved for the Scheduled Tribes). In practice, however, instead of fostering leadership, that noble intent often devolves into its perverse opposite.